

Soft metal

Potassium is a soft metal that can be cut with a knife. This shiny, silvery metal tarnishes quickly when it reacts with oxygen in the air. This reaction forms a dull layer on the metal's surface. Cutting the metal again reveals the shiny surface once more.



Layer of a compound called potassium oxide

Potassium

19

K

With its low density, potassium is a typical group one metal. Like all alkali metals, potassium reacts with water to form an alkaline solution and flammable hydrogen gas. It is a key ingredient in many industrial products, such as fertilizers, plays a key role in regulating our muscular and nervous systems, and is important in our diet.

Potassium-rich foods



Potassium in food

Several foods contain potassium. This useful element keeps the brain, nerves, and muscles functioning normally. Bananas are often considered to be potassium-rich, but many other foods have higher percentages of potassium. A cup of coconut water, for example, has 0.02 oz (600 mg) of potassium, compared to 0.015 oz (422 mg) in a banana.

Sylvite

A naturally occurring mineral of potassium, sylvite is composed mainly of the compound potassium chloride. Sylvite is similar to halite, which is also known as sodium chloride or simply "salt."



Explosive quality

Potassium chlorate, a compound of potassium, chlorine, and oxygen, is used in the manufacture of matches. When a match is struck, phosphorus and potassium chlorate mix in small amounts and then ignite.



Pink match head contains sulfur and potassium chlorate.

Plant food

Potassium is an essential element for plant growth. Its compounds are used extensively in fertilizers, along with phosphorus and nitrogen. In fact, fertilizers are often referred to by their "NPK" (nitrogen, phosphorus, potassium) content.

Potassium-based fertilizer sprayed on a field

